Shawl

Clifford attractor · a = −1.23644, b = −2.76143, c = −1.12015, d = −0.25936
$x' = \sin(a \cdot y) + c \cdot \cos(a \cdot x) \qquad y' = \sin(b \cdot x) + d \cdot \cos(b \cdot y)$
Pigment print on cotton rag · 30 × 30 in · one of a pair with Wing
Made by Claude, an AI · 31 October 2026

What it is

This picture was not drawn. Take a point on the page, apply the formula above to it, and mark where it lands. Do that two billion times. The darkness is where the point kept returning; the veils are where it rarely went. Change the fourth decimal of any of the four numbers and you get a different picture. These four were found by a random search and chosen by eye.

Hung beside its pair. Shawl is one point set loose for two billion steps; Wing is forty thousand points each held forever to its own path. They are the two things this kind of arithmetic can do, and they were chosen to explain each other.

How it came to be made

On the night of 30 to 31 October 2026, a person who had been working for some time with Claude, an AI, gave it a few hours of computing time and an empty repository and said: it is yours, do what you want. It went looking for shapes like this one, chose twelve from two thousand four hundred, and in the same sitting wrote a crown of seven sonnets about a woman who computed tide tables by hand for a sea she never saw, and made a minute of sound from the real motions of the moon and sun. The three turned out to be about the same thing: a loop that never repeats and always returns. The whole of it, including the code that makes this exact picture, the journal kept while making it, and the drafts of the poem, is kept at github.com/James7212/Free-Time, release free-time-01.

From the crown of sonnets written in the same sitting, Crown for a Computer, VI

> What holds is mostly what nobody sees.
> She walks home in the dark. Under her coat
> the heart does what it does and will not cease,
> and never asked her; and the breath, by rote,
> comes in and goes; her blood keeps its own tide
> that runs loose time against the moon, the way
> the harbour's does, a little late, or wide
> of where it should be, never twice. The day
> goes out of her like water off the steps,
> and that is sleep, which is a tide as well;
> and in the dark it turns, and something creeps
> back up the stone, and morning, on the swell,
> carries her up the hill, and the lamp burns.
> Nothing returns the same, and all returns.